Questions to Answer Before We Decide

Fifteen questions for your loved one, each other and the professionals, sorted by who can answer, with room to write what they say.

Some of the questions in front of your family belong to your loved one. Some belong to the relatives. Some can only be answered by a doctor, a nurse or another professional, and no amount of talking at the kitchen table will settle them.

This guide sorts the questions by who can answer. It doesn't answer them and doesn't say which matters most. Bring them written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one.

Your loved one

The questions only they can answer. Write what they say, the way they say it.

1. What matters most to you right now?

2. What does a good day look like for you?

3. Which routines and choices do you want to keep, whatever gets decided?

4. What worries you about the decision that's coming?

5. Here is what we wrote down from what you told us. Did we get it right?

Each relative involved

Everyone gets the same questions, including the relative who hasn't said much yet.

1. What are you most worried about?

2. What outcome do you hope for?

3. What can you realistically do yourself, and what can't you do?

4. Where do you think the family already agrees, and where do you see it differently?

5. What do you think we still need to find out before we decide?

The doctor or the nurse

For the questions about your loved one's health that the family can't answer and shouldn't have to guess at.

1. Here is the decision the family is facing. What should we understand about our loved one's health before we make it?

2. The family sees one thing differently: _____. What can you tell us that would help us understand it?

3. May we tell you what our loved one has said matters to them, so that it's in front of you as well?

A social worker or discharge planner, if one is involved

Hospitals and larger medical practices often have a social worker on staff.

1. Which of our open questions can you help with, and who should we take the others to?

A care consultant

Someone who asks your loved one what is important to them, as well as listening to the family.

1. Here are our loved one's own words, where the family agrees and where it doesn't. What else would you want to know before we decide?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, put them in order of importance, or say what the family should do once they're answered. If one of them feels pressing to you, say so to the person you're asking.

Ready for the next step?

You know whose question each one is, and soon you'll have some answers. The care interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it walks you through your loved one's situation area by area and turns what you tell it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Bringing a written list of questions and writing down the answers follows the National Institute on Aging's tips for appointments, which also note where a social worker is often found. Telling the care team about the person follows the Institute's tips for caregivers and families. The questions themselves, and the grouping by who can answer, come from the Family Care Roadmap's working list for this step.

1. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers
2. National Institute on Aging, Advance Care Planning and Health Care Decisions: Tips for Caregivers and Families